

74 The Queen of Sheba

A foreign queen who traveled far to test Solomon's wisdom, and went home praising Israel's God.

The Queen of Sheba ruled a wealthy land far to the south of Israel. She heard of Solomon's fame "concerning the name of the LORD," and came with a great caravan to test him with hard questions. Solomon answered everything she asked. Seeing his wisdom, his house and his worship, she confessed that "the half was not told me," and blessed the LORD. Scripture does not give her name. Yet Jesus held her up as an example: she traveled far to hear Solomon, and "a greater than Solomon" had now come.

At a glance

Name	Not given; "the queen of the south" (Matthew 12:42)
Homeland	Sheba, likely southwest Arabia (Yemen); some say Ethiopia
When	During Solomon's reign, c. 970–931 BC; year not given
Came with	Camels bearing spices, gold and precious stones
Gift to Solomon	120 talents of gold and many spices (1 Kings 10:10)
Key people	Solomon
New Testament	Matthew 12:42; Luke 11:31

"Howbeit I believed not the words, until I came, and mine eyes had seen it: and, behold, the half was not told me."

1 Kings 10:7, KJV

The life of The Queen of Sheba

Scripture gives no dates or ages for the queen. Her visit came sometime during Solomon's reign (c. 970–931 BC), after his fame had spread widely.

In Sheba	Hears of Solomon News reaches her of Solomon's fame "concerning the name of the LORD." She decides to test him for herself with hard questions. <i>1 Kings 10:1; 2 Chronicles 9:1</i>
The journey	Arrives in Jerusalem She comes with a very great train of camels bearing spices, gold and precious stones. She talks with Solomon about all that is in her heart. <i>1 Kings 10:2</i>
At the court	Tests and sees Solomon answers all her questions; nothing is hidden from him. She sees his wisdom, his house, his food, his servants and his offerings, and "there was no more spirit in her." <i>1 Kings 10:3–5</i>
Before leaving	Blesses Israel's God She says the reports were true and "the half was not told me." She blesses the LORD for setting Solomon on Israel's throne and gives rich gifts. <i>1 Kings 10:6–10</i>
Going home	Receives all she desires Solomon gives her all she desires and asks for, beyond the gifts he gives her from his royal bounty. Then she turns and goes back to her own country with her servants. <i>1 Kings 10:13; 2 Chronicles 9:12</i>

Group notes

Key activities

1 Kings 10 and 2 Chronicles 9 tell the same story in almost the same words. Compare them side by side.

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- 1 Sought the truth for herself.** She did not rest on reports but came to see and hear. *1 Kings 10:1, 6-7*
 - 2 Asked hard questions.** She came "to prove him with hard questions," and spoke with him of all that was in her heart. *1 Kings 10:1-3*
 - 3 Observed carefully.** She took in his wisdom, his house, his table, his servants and his worship at the house of the LORD. *1 Kings 10:4-5*
 - 4 Admitted she was wrong.** "I believed not the words, until I came, and mine eyes had seen it." *1 Kings 10:7*
 - 5 Praised God.** "Blessed be the LORD thy God, which delighted in thee, to set thee on the throne of Israel." *1 Kings 10:9*
 - 6 Gave generously.** She gave a hundred and twenty talents of gold and more spices than ever came again. *1 Kings 10:10*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names the queen.

Old Testament

1 Kings 10:1-13; 2 Chronicles 9:1-12	The two accounts of her visit
Psalms 72:10, 15	"The kings of Sheba and Seba shall offer gifts"
Isaiah 60:6	"All they from Sheba shall come"
Echo: Ruth 1:16; 2 Kings 5:15	Outsiders who honor Israel's God

New Testament

Matthew 12:42; Luke 11:31	She came "from the uttermost parts of the earth"
Echo: Matthew 2:11	Wise men bring gold, frankincense and myrrh
Echo: Acts 8:27-39	An Ethiopian official hears the gospel

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did the queen see in Jerusalem, and how did she respond (1 Kings 10:4-9)?
2. *Understand:* Jesus said "a greater than Solomon is here." What was he saying about himself, and about those who would not listen to him?
3. *Apply:* The queen brought her hard questions. What hard questions would you like to bring to God?
4. *Apply:* She traveled a long way to hear wisdom. What effort are you willing to make this week to hear from God?